lift the morale of a party that is in deep depression. A question that was first posed after its 1977 debacle is being heard with even greater frequency now —is the Congress finished?

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Within a few weeks of leading his party to defeat, Rahul Gandhi was flying off abroad. June can be awfully hot in Delhi, and Rahul clearly wanted to beat the heat. But it wasn't just the rising temperatures he wanted to avoid —it appeared that he didn't want to confront the growing disquiet being felt within the Congress.

When the sixteenth Lok Sabha was convened, the expectation was that Rahul would be the Congress's leader in Parliament. Instead, he shied away from taking up responsibility once again—the seventy-two-year-old veteran Congress leader from Karnataka, Mallikarjun Kharge, was chosen instead. Kharge, a Gandhi family loyalist, has won a record ten consecutive elections, but the truth is, he isn't going to set the Yamuna on fire. By choosing to opt out, Rahul had once again demonstrated an inability to lead from the front. Even his self-styled political guru Digvijaya Singh was disheartened. 'When the going gets tough, the tough must get going. Rahul is making a mistake by not taking up the challenge,' he told me. Privately, Congress leaders whispered that maybe Rahul didn't want to sit in the front row of the Lok Sabha where he would be caught out if he dozed off!

A contrast could be drawn with Indira Gandhi who had found herself in a similar difficult position after the 1977 election disaster. She was jailed, her party split, she was written off, and yet, quite remarkably, she made a comeback in three years, her fighting spirit best exemplified by the enduring image of her on an elephant striding across the floodwaters of Belchi in Bihar to meet marooned Dalit villagers who had been brutally attacked. Even Sonia had shown some of that political courage when she refused to buckle under the foreign origin propaganda against her. It is the kind of resolve which Rahul, it seems, is incapable of demonstrating. The *Economist*, in a scathing piece, wrote: 'Rahul, who had been long groomed